Domination of Black and Cobra Lilies in the Supermarket

By Wallace Stevens and Diane Wakoski

INTRODUCTION

The distinctive eye-like pattern of the peacocks regal tail feathers symbolizes the all-seeing power of God to many Christians. The peacock also represents immortality and resurrection, for it was believed that the flesh of the peacock never spoiled. When peacocks cry, then, the logical question is against what are they protesting? Wallace Stevens paints a wonderfully symbolic image of peacocks crying in response to the inevitable coming of night – Or on a deeper level: God crying out against the universal symbol of evil and death . . . . . Domination of Black.by Wallace Stevens

Domination of Black

At night, by the fire,

The colors of the bushes

And of the fallen leaves,

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Repeating themselves,

Turned in the room,

Like the leaves themselves

Turning in the wind.

Yes: but the color of the heavy hemlocks

Came striding.

And I remembered the cry of the peacocks.

The colors of their tails

Were like the leaves themselves

Turning in the wind,

In the twilight wind.

They swept over the room,

Just as they flew from the boughs of the hemlocks

Down to the ground.

I heard them cry -- the peacocks.

Was it a cry against the twilight

Or against the leaves themselves

Turning in the wind,

Turning as the flames

Turned in the fire,

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Turning as the tails of the peacocks

Turned in the loud fire,

Loud as the hemlocks

Full of the cry of the peacocks?

Or was it a cry against the hemlocks?

Out of the window,

I saw how the planets gathered

Like the leaves themselves

Turning in the wind.

I saw how the night came,

Came striding like the color of the heavy hemlocks

I felt afraid.

And I remembered the cry of the peacocks.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Wallace Stevens
Book: The Emperor of Ice-Cream and Other Poems
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TRANSITION

Diane Wakoski uses the cries of Stevens's peacocks to derive some insight into her own tendency toward tears. Society often views crying as a sign of weakness, rather than a protest of injustice. However, in spite of mixed feelings about tears, poets and novelists have known intuitively that crying is somehow good for us. For example, Shakespeare wrote: "To weep is to make less the depth of grief." And Tennyson once wrote about a woman who learned her military husband was killed: "She must weep or she will die." But, perhaps the best advice about tears comes from Charles Dickens, who has Mr. Bumble, in Oliver Twist, declare that crying "opens the lungs, washes the countenance, exercises the eyes, and softens down the temper. So cry away." Even if it's over something as insignificant as Cobra Lilies in the Supermarket by Diane Wakoski.

Cobra Lilies In The Supermarket
for Wallace Stevens

I wonder

as I am driving to the Market Basket why I have lived

my life

as I have.

The mother of

my third husband
-a blond blue-eyed singer, she was

told me
I was a crybaby
because,
at the time,
I was crying.
She said
you should fix up your life and then not cry
about it.

My own mother
said, referring to my fourth husband
who left me

"What are you crying for?
Buy your own house so that the next one who leaves you
won't be able to take your home away."
And she too said,
"You always were

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a crybaby."

When I cry now
it is usually in anger. But
sometimes
I still cry in pain. Then I hide myself in rooms where no
one can see me.
I bought a house
but cannot live in it.
My fifth husband says he would leave me
before living there,
and since he is a nice man
(or perhaps it is just thatI am older)
I didn't cry,
nor have I recently been called
a crybaby.

I stilI live in other people's houses,
listen to their music,
live out of suitcases.

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Driving to the supermarket in the rain today, shopping
for someone else's dinner,
I wondered if anyone ever felt
he had a home
other than in his head.

I was tantalized with the cobra lily sitting next to the
oranges & avocados like a purple clenched fist
unrolling its tongue
but unwilling to speak to me, I thought.

When I studied the piano
I always cried at my music lessons. My teacher stopped
criticizing me. I heard that secretly she called me a
crybaby.
I gave up piano
Took up voice instead.
Now,
my lessons are concerts
where crying is considered an art.
I shout,

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I speak,
I whisper,
and at last again
I can cry.
This time
no one taunts me
but other crybabies;
and when I am alone
I defend myself with poetry:
"I remember the cry of the peacocks."

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Diane Wakoski
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